Malwinder Singh Kang, who clambered on board during the 2020-21 farm protests. They've also got three ex-Congis padded up—Raj Kumar Chabbewal, MLA from (where else) Chabbewal, has been upgraded to Hoshiarpur; former Bassi Pathana MLA Gurpreet Singh G.P. to Fatehgarh Sahib; and Gurmeet Singh Khuddian, who'd already proved his giant-killing skills by outjumping Parkash Singh Badal from Lambi in 2022, gets scaled up to Bathinda. The Akalis, scouting for Hindu faces to contest urban seats, may just pick BJP turncoat Anil Joshi for Amritsar. Most parties are in secret talks across border fences to fill up the remaining seats. That's why a scared Congress is delaying its list—what if they lose a candidate before he has a chance to lose! The crowning ignominy will be if Charanjit Singh Channi tilts saffronward—the ex-CM made an impromptu trip to the Ram temple in Ayodhya recently. ■



▶ BENGAL

JUMLA BABA

The Trinamool Congress's mini-series of animated films called Jumla Baba didn't disappoint (though the title possibly is a plot spoiler). The first film, released on April 1, shows an angry citizenry storming the new Parliament building to protest inflation, unemployment and the stingy flow of central funds, while a character who looks suspiciously like the dear PM dances with a quartet whose resemblance to Shah, Yogi, Suvendu Adhikari and Dilip Ghosh is also quite uncanny. Confronted, they choose to flee. The second video shows the bearded one riding a scooter and delivering packages marked 'ED' and 'CBI'.... But when he reaches the land of the Hooghly, the screen shows 'Bengal rejects BJP'. ■

BETWEEN THE LINES



"If you give him a lead of 60,000 votes, I'll be happy"

CM SIDDARAMAIAH campaigning for the Congress candidate in home base Varuna, Mysuru

"You had given (Congress) the highest number of (assembly) seats in Mandya district keeping me in mind. Your wish will not be in vain"

DEPUTY CM D.K. SHIVAKUMAR to Mandya voters



SULTANS OF AASMAN

It's harvest season for India's charter flight operators, as eager candidates hop on to rented choppers and small aircraft with sky-high ambitions. Soaring along with them is the revenue graph of these private 'non-schedule operators' (NSOps)—India has around 110 of them, half with just one aircraft, but all booked out for the next two months. "The demand is huge. Bookings happen well in advance," says Capt. R.K. Bali, MD, Business Aircraft Operators Association. Choppers are more popular due to how they allow netas to raise dust in the interiors. Fixed-wing aircraft are for the big



fish state-hopping on a single day. Those who fly business class go for the Falcon 2000, whose 9- and 12-seater versions go for Rs 5.25 lakh per hour. The smaller Cessna Citations and Super King B200s, which can cart 4-9 or 6-7 each, set you back by Rs 3.5 lakh and Rs 2.75 lakh per ride. The rotary blade club is cheaper: a Bell 407 or an Agusta A109C can be had for Rs 1.5-2 lakh an hour, seating 4-6 or 6-7 party heavies and chelas (their hand luggage of empty promises is light enough). ■